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Track Name: AIC2026

Paper ID: 2721

Paper Title: Health and Safety Systems in the Oil and Gas Post Covid

Abstract:

Abstract

This study is a deep dive analysis on the resilience and structural changes observed in Health and Safety Management Systems (HSMS) within the Oil & Gas industry, with a focus on the period beginning with the initial shock of the COVID-19 crisis through the current recovery phase. The Oil & Gas industry is certainly no stranger to high-risk environments; however, the stressors posed by the pandemic—remote oversight, disintegrated teams, and a fluid regulatory environment—were never intended to be managed under traditional safety management systems. This study employed a qualitative case study approach to understand how organizations have evolved beyond the traditional "survival mode" to adapt their safety management systems on the operational, behavioral, and technological fronts.

Our research indicates that while business continuity was eventually achieved, the notion of "resilience" for these organizations was a mixed bag, with some teams' success tied more to team culture than corporate-level directives. We also discuss the "Digital Paradox" that arose during this period: where IoT and remote monitoring capabilities were a key enabler for business continuity, they also created new challenges in workforce usability and mental well-being. Moreover, the emphasis on increased individual accountability also led to a marked increase in safety awareness among the front-line workforce; however, this came with a visible cost to workforce well-being. This paper argues that the new "New Normal" for the oil and gas industry post-pandemic requires a fundamental recalibration that balances high-tech capabilities with a renewed focus on leadership and workforce engagement to achieve peak safety performance in crisis situations going forward.

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